

The Sūtra of the Great Assembly

Mahāsamayasūtra · Toh 34 · Derge Kangyur

འདས་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛོད་

The Sūtra of the Great Assembly, known in Sanskrit as the Mahāsamayasūtra and in Tibetan as Düpa Chenpo'i Do (ཏཱཔ་ཆེན་པོའི་དོ་), is a canonical Buddhist sūtra recounting a vast celestial gathering in which the gods of ten world-systems converge to behold the Buddha and his community of five hundred arhats in the Śākya land. The text celebrates this great assembly by enumerating the many divine beings who come to pay homage, making it a remarkable panoramic vision of the Buddhist cosmos and its inhabitants. It belongs to the genre of sūtra literature and is catalogued as Toh 34 in the Kangyur, the Tibetan canon of texts attributed to the Buddha himself.

Requested and set down in final form. May it be like the sun and moon upon the earth.

In the language of India: Mahāsamayasūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Sūtra of the Great Assembly. With reverence I bow to the noble Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in the great grove of the Śākya land called Sers-kya, together with a great Saṅgha of five hundred monks, all of them arhats. The gods of the ten world-systems assembled at once in order to behold the Blessed One and the Saṅgha of monks.

Then the four orders of gods of the Pure Abode spoke as follows: "Here too the Blessed One dwells in the great grove of the Śākya land called Sers-kya, together with a great Saṅgha of five hundred monks, all of them arhats. The gods of the ten world-systems have assembled at once in order to behold the Blessed One and the Saṅgha of monks. Those who wish to go before the Blessed One should go there and, having gone, recite verses separately in the presence of the Blessed One."

Then those gods, just as a strong man might extend a bent arm or bend an extended arm, vanished from the Pure Abode and appeared before the Blessed One. Those gods then bowed to the Blessed One and stood to one side. Standing to one side, those gods offered these verses in the presence of the Blessed One:

In this grove of the Great Assembly
the hosts of gods have gathered.

For the sake of this Dharma I have come
to behold the unconquered Saṅgha.

Then other gods offered this verse in the presence of the Blessed One:

The Saṅgha, their minds tamed,
have made their own minds straight.
As a charioteer holds the reins,
so do the wise guard their faculties.

Then other gods offered this verse in the presence of the Blessed One:

Having cut the bonds of home,
the mind moves away from the senses,
going there, pure and stainless,
like a sighted elephant, well-tamed.

Then other gods offered this verse in the presence of the Blessed One:

Whoever takes refuge in the Buddha
will not go to the lower realms.
Having given up a human body,
they will fully obtain a divine body.

Then the Blessed One called the monks and said at once: "Monks, the gods of the ten world-systems have assembled in order to behold the Tathāgata together with the Saṅgha of monks. As many as those arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas, have been in the past — just as many gods as there were for those Blessed Ones have now assembled here as well. I too shall now speak thus. Monks, the names of the divine hosts are to be proclaimed. Monks, there is the divine host called 'those who illuminate greatly,' and monks, there is the divine host called 'those who show the way.' Hear this, take it well to heart, and I shall explain."

Accordingly, the monks individually made their request to the venerable Blessed One, and the Blessed One declared:

The verses I shall explain separately.
Wherever flat ground is seen
and one dwells in a mountain cave,
there one should enter into equipoise.
On the open ground, fearless as a lion,
without even a hair's breadth of trembling,

the mind pure and clear,
like water utterly transparent —
the five hundred, knowing well
the many dwelling-places of the Sers-kya grove,
were then called by the Teacher, the monk.

The śrāvakas who delight in the Teaching,
and the hosts of gods who came —
let the monks know this:
without tormenting the body,
through hearing the Buddha's Teaching,
those ones will be illumined by gnosis.
Those who behold the non-humans:
one who sees a hundred,
one who sees a thousand and seventy,
one who sees a hundred thousand and a thousand —
they will behold the non-humans.
One who sees them without limit,
who sees them filling every direction —
those monks, having understood
and examined with clear-seeing eyes,
were therefore called by the Teacher.

The śrāvakas who delight in the Teaching,
and the hosts of gods who came —
let the monks know this:
I shall explain to whoever would hear,
so listen in due order.

The seven thousand yakṣas (Skt. yakṣa)
dwelling in the ground of the Sers-kya grove,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

The six thousand yakṣas of the Snow Mountains,
their bodies of varied colors,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,

endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

The five hundred various good friends,
yakṣas of bodies of varied colors,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

The yakṣas of the realm, the crocodile,
dwelling on the broad-faced mountains,
the single one of great power,
attended by a retinue of yakṣas —
the yakṣa of the realm, the crocodile,
entered the grove of monks in peace.

The king of the eastern direction,
whose name is Dhṛtarāṣṭra, Protector of the Land (Skt. Dhṛtarāṣṭra),
lord of the gandharvas (Skt. gandharva),
a great king of great renown —
his many sons,
all known by a single name,
called Powerful Ones, of great strength,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

The king of the southern direction,
whose name is Virūḍhaka (Skt. Virūḍhaka),
lord of the kumbhāṇḍas (Skt. kumbhāṇḍa),
a great king of great renown —
his many sons,
all known by a single name,
called Powerful Ones, of great strength,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,

came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

The king of the western direction,
known by the name Virūpākṣa (Skt. Virūpākṣa),
lord of the nāgas,
a great king of great renown —
his many sons,
all known by a single name,
called Powerful Ones, endowed with strength,
possessed of miraculous power and endowed with strength,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

The king of the northern direction,
known by the name Vaiśravaṇa (Skt. Vaiśravaṇa),
lord of the yakṣas,
a great king of great renown —
his many sons,
all known by a single name,
called Powerful Ones, of great strength,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

In the east, Dhṛtarāṣṭra;
in the south, Virūḍhaka;
in the west, Virūpākṣa;
in the north, Vaiśravaṇa —
these are the Four Great Kings,
present throughout all four directions,
arrayed in blazing splendor,
in the grove of the Sers-kya ground.

They, imagining illusory sport,
those with their retinues stood in the sky.
The illusory Kuṭeṇya, Vaiḍaṇu,

Virya, Śīvīrīḍo, and together with them —
Candana, Desired Excellence, and

Beautiful-necked and Sure-necked,
the steersmen born from among the gods,
the hosts of gandharvas (fragrance-eaters) of every kind,
those who have become the chief flock of the Victor among men,
and before them the Five Summits, likewise
Gyerma, Sunbeam,
and the kings of these and others —
the kings, together with their gandharvas,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

Then, moreover, the nāgas of the sky
who dwell together in Vaiśālī —
Lava, Finest of Horses,
Excellent-Goer with his companions,
Yamunā and Viṣayakṣema,
the Kinsmen of the Nāgas and the Renowned,
and the great earth-guarding elephants —
these too were in the wooded grove.

He who swiftly receives the nāga kings,
with eyes pure as those of gods and birds,
came from the sky and arrived at that grove —
his name is Manifold-Beautiful-Wings.
Through the gift of fearlessness, that king of nāgas
was understood with the patience of garuḍas.
Not contending with one another,
nāgas and garuḍas alike take refuge in the Buddha.

Vajrapāṇi, the Victor,
and the asuras dwelling in the ocean,
their kinsmen and their dwelling place,
possessed of majesty and possessed of renown —
Dark Eye-Collyrium, the Fearsome-One,
those who anger the asuras,
Thagzang and the Thagzang clan,

Markajaya, Namotī and his companions,
the eight sons of Power —
all bearing the name Vairocana,
the host of Power arrayed in ranks,
Good Rāhu going at the fore —
that venerable assembly gathered together
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

Water, gods, earth,
fire, and wind also came there.
The water gods, the gods of water,
the Moon, possessed of renown,
those with an assembly of loving-kindness and compassion,
and the renowned god in the vanguard —
the assemblies of beings from the ten directions,
all with bodies of various colors,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

Viṣṇu together with his gods,
each arriving separately,
the gods of the Moon's retinue
with the Moon at their head, and with their train,
and the gods of the Sun's retinue
with the Sun at their head, and with their train,
and those of the constellation's retinue
with Haka going before,
Earth and the Lord of the Earth,
and Śakra (Indra), the ever-giving,
and the assemblies of beings from the ten directions —
all with bodies of various colors,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

Then the gods of provisions,
like the crests of fire and water,
sounding and making light,
and those like the flower of the umā plant —
together with the water gods, Dharma
and Acyuta and the many —
in the vanguard of the Beautiful Receivers of Good,
the vanguard and dwelling-place, and many besides,
and the assemblies of beings from the ten directions —
all with bodies of various colors,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

The assembled and the great assembled,
humans and the finest among humans,
those with rank in divine sport going before,
Finest-Mind and the Summit of Rank —
then those worthy of divine honor,
and those wearing red garments,
the great jewels reaching to the far shore,
the greatly renowned standing in the gods' vanguard —
and the assemblies of beings from the ten directions,
all with bodies of various colors,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

White, Hot, and Red,
deep blue and dense together,
White-Grasper and the rest —
the wise gods going in the vanguard.
Ever causing great elephants to run in rut,
the Mixed and the Renowned,
Prajñuna, many, going before —
those who adorn the directions,
and the assemblies of beings from the ten directions,

all with bodies of various colors,
possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance,
endowed with beauty and with renown,
came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse
and entered the grove of monks in peace.

The six groups of varied kind,
all with bodies of various colors,
the Renowned going in the vanguard,
together like another household,
declaring the lineage without remainder,
the undefiled assembly having crossed to the far shore,
the host of great elephants, the beholders,
Moon, Laughter, and the Three-Endowed,
Brahmā the Good and the Supreme Attainment,
the son possessed of miraculous power,
and the youth who is his joy —
all these entered the grove in peace.

In the thousand Brahmā worlds,
Mahābrahmā was close at hand,
those born endowed with radiance,
the Renowned with bodies of varied kinds,
the ten Īśvaras going in the vanguard,
each having come into their own sovereignty,
in whose center and before whom
Pramocā came with her retinue.

All of these then arrived:
Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods) came along with Brahmā,
and the hosts of Māra came,
to look into the mind of Gautama.
"Seize this one! Bind him!" they cried,
like a rutting elephant being bound with chains —
yet encircled by their retinues and surrounded on all sides,
there was nowhere that was empty of them.

But in the face of all this, great bliss prevailed,
and they could do no harm to the assembly of Gautama.

They clapped their hands
and raised a frightening clamor.
Yet just as wind scatters clouds,
dark masses shot through with lightning —
that very instant, free of terror,
the mind rested without agitation.

All those gods and Brahmā bowed before the Blessed One, circumambulated him, and vanished from that very spot. The hosts of Māra, too, departed in silence, saying nothing.

The Teacher then called to those śrāvakas who delight in the teaching:

He who causes fearlessness,
in the teaching of the pure Buddha —
fearless, free of attachment,
not even a hair of his stirring —
victorious in every battle,
having gone beyond fear and possessed of renown,
proclaimed together with the gods,
and the śrāvakas resting there.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those monks rejoiced greatly at what the Blessed One had taught.

The Mahāsamāja Sūtra is complete.

Heard from the mouth of the paṇḍita Ānandaśrī and translated by the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltzen Pal.

Translator's Notes

- The place name "Sers-skya" rendered from the Tibetan as "Sers-kya" is the Tibetan transcription of what the Sanskrit tradition identifies as Kapilavatthu or a grove associated with the Śākya clan. The text does not give a Sanskrit equivalent here beyond "Śākya land," so the Tibetan toponym is retained in translation.

The final verse block is somewhat elliptical in the source, especially the last two lines, where the syntax shifts abruptly from describing the monks' state to the Teacher summoning them. The rendering follows the most natural grammatical reading.

- The passage is a verse catalogue of the supernatural beings who assembled to hear the Dharma, drawn from a text closely paralleling the Āṭṇāṭiya-sūtra tradition. The Tibetan names for the Four Great Kings are rendered here by their standard Sanskrit equivalents: Yul-'khor-srung equals Dhṛtarāṣṭra; 'Phags-skyes-po equals Virūḍhaka; Mig-mi-bzang equals Virūpākṣa; Lus-ngan-po equals Vaiśravaṇa. The "crocodile yakṣa of the realm" is a particular

local deity figure whose identity is not fully determinable from context alone. The final line of the passage breaks off mid-list, and the names Kuṭeṇya, Vaiḍaṇu, Virya, and Śīvirīḍo are attempted transliterations from the Tibetan phonetic rendering of what appear to be Sanskrit yakṣa names; the precise Sanskrit originals are uncertain.

- Several divine and semi-divine names in this passage are highly Sanskritized or corrupt in the Tibetan and resist confident reconstruction. Names such as Kuṭeṇya, Vaiḍaṇu, Virya, Śīvirīḍo from the preceding passage, and in this passage Thagzang, Namoṭi, Haka, Acyuta, Prajñuna, and Gyerma, are rendered in approximate transliteration, as their Sanskrit originals are uncertain or the Tibetan forms appear to be phonetic transcriptions of Sanskrit names that cannot be uniquely identified. This is characteristic of the Mahāsamājasūtra tradition, which contains unusually long catalogues of divine beings with obscure names.

The passage belongs to the Mahāsamājasūtra, a text listing the vast assembly gathered to hear the Buddha teach. Many name-lists in this text are philologically difficult across all surviving witnesses.

The refrain "all with bodies of various colors, possessed of miraculous power and possessed of radiance, endowed with beauty and with renown, came here for the sake of a Dharma discourse and entered the grove of monks in peace" is a recurring liturgical formula and has been rendered consistently throughout.

- The six groups named in the middle stanzas (the six groups of varied kind, along with names such as Moon, Laughter, the Three-Endowed, Brahmā the Good, Pramocā, and the ten Īśvaras) are deity-class groupings standard to the Mahāsamāja Sūtra's divine assembly lists. The Tibetan names here are metrically condensed epithets of celestial beings and Brahmā-world deities; their Sanskrit equivalents in the underlying tradition include Candrasasā (Moon-Laughter), Śubhakarīśa (Brahmā the Good), Vaśavartin (Sovereigns or Īśvaras), and Pramocā (a celestial female attendant). These names are preserved as close renderings of the Tibetan rather than normalized to reconstructed Sanskrit, since the Tibetan itself appears to reflect a corrupt or telescoped transmission of what was originally a longer roster.

The colophon names the translator as the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltzen Pal, who heard the text from the paṇḍita Ānandaśrī. This colophon formula is standard for later Tibetan canonical translations revised under Indian scholarly supervision.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.

